

Dvar Torah Outline — כוס של אליהו, כוס חמישי, הלל and the Greatness of Hashem as the "עילה" Who Sustains All Existence

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's approach to the structure of the cups at the Seder, emphasizing that the Gemara's primary girsa points to two distinct cups beyond the basic four: the fourth for Hallel (with ברכת השיר) and an additional fifth connected to הלל הגדול. From there, Rabbi Shulman develops the Maharal's central theological idea: why הלל הגדול is "great"—because it highlights Hashem not only as Creator but as the constant Sustainer, the "עילה" upon which all "עלולים" (dependent beings) rely for ongoing existence and פרנסה. He then connects the 26 refrains of "כי לעולם חסדו" to Shem Havayah (יהוה), and begins unpacking the hierarchy of angelic roles implied by "אליהי" האלהים and "אדוני האדונים".

I. Framing the sugya: כוס של אליהו and the question of a fifth cup

A. The Maharal's preferred girsa in the Gemara

- Rabbi Shulman notes that the Maharal sides with what he views as the standard girsa across "all the sefarim":
 - There are **two separate elements**:
 1. כוס רביעי for הלל together with ברכת השיר
 2. כוס חמישי for הלל הגדול (the series of 26 "הודו" phrases)

B. Rejecting the Rashbam's divergent girsa

- Rabbi Shulman reports the Maharal's sharp stance:
 - The Rashbam had a different reading, perhaps closer to contemporary practice, but:
 - "ואין דבריו נגד כל מפרשים" — the Rashbam cannot outweigh the consensus of the other מפרשים.

C. Practical bottom line (as Rabbi Shulman practices)

- Four cups are obligatory.
 - The fifth cup is framed as either:
 - **מצוה מן המובחר**, or
 - **רשות** (optional), provided it is treated as such.
 - Rabbi Shulman's own practice:
 - He says he **does make a fifth cup for נרצה**.
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II. Today's minhag and where הלל הגדול fits (2:00)

A. Common contemporary practice

- Rabbi Shulman observes: **"ואין אנו נוהגים בכוס חמישי"**—many do not drink a fifth cup nowadays.

B. The liturgical order as commonly done

- People typically recite:
 - **הלל הגדול** immediately after **הלל**
 - and then say **נשמת**, which functions as **ברכת השיר** (in their current ordering).
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III. Why is הלל הגדול "great"? Hashem "sits on high and distributes sustenance" (2:32)

A. The Gemara's definition of הלל הגדול

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Gemara in Pesachim (ק"ח ע"א):
 - is "great" because **הקדוש ברוך הוא יושב ברומו של עולם ומחלק מזון לכל ההלל הגדול ברייה**.

B. First explanation: פרנסה is "כללי" (universal), unlike creation which is "פרטי"

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's first approach:
 - **Creation** of each being is individual/particular.

- **Sustaining all beings** through פרנסה is a comprehensive, all-encompassing governance.
- Metaphor:
 - The higher one sits atop the “pyramid,” the more one’s influence encompasses everything at once.

C. Second explanation (“ועוד”): Hashem as עילה; all created beings as חסר

- Rabbi Shulman develops the Maharal’s deeper metaphysics:
 - Hashem is the **עילה** (the משפיע, the causal “Giver”) of all existence.
 - All created beings are **עלולים** (receivers), and by definition are **חסרים** (lacking).
- Key conceptual step:
 - To be a recipient implies a “void” needing to be filled—an inherent חסרון.
- Therefore:
 - Existence is not “self-sustaining” for creations; it requires continuous bestowal.

D. פרנסה as “maintenance of existence,” even higher than “creation”

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the Maharal’s claim:
 - פרנסה is not merely giving food; it represents **קיום הנברא**—keeping the created being in existence.
 - This gives “מזון” a “מדרגה” higher than the one-time act of creation.
- Rabbi Shulman notes the Maharal’s closing line here:
 - These ideas are “clear,” yet also contain deeper “נפלאים ועמוקים” to be explained further.

IV. Clarifying the “first explanation” vs. the (11:08) “ועוד”

A. Rabbi Shulman’s summary distinction

- First explanation:
 - Creation is **פרטי**, while sustaining via פרנסה is **כללי**.

- Second explanation:
 - Not only do all need sustenance; **why** they need it is essential:
 - because as עלולים they lack independent existence and must be continuously upheld by the עילה.

B. Sensitivity to the length and density of the Maharal

- Rabbi Shulman and the group note that the idea feels simple but runs across multiple paragraphs.
- Resolution:
 - Part of the “length” is due to how it is formatted/printed, but Rabbi Shulman agrees there may be further depth not yet fully extracted.

V. The 26 refrains of “כי לעולם חסדו” and Shem Havayah as the source of existence (12:30)

A. Transition: beyond “נותן לחם לכל בשר”

- Rabbi Shulman explains that until now they were focused on the specific line:
 - “נותן לחם לכל בשר” (He gives bread to all flesh)
- He briefly connects it to a discussion in Berachot:
 - A “הוה אמינא” to say “הודו” daily instead of אשרי, rejected because אשרי has:
 - the ordered בית אלף (though missing the נון),
 - and “פוחת את ידך ומשביע לכל חי רצון” (a broader/spiritual framing), whereas “לחם לכל בשר” stresses physical provision.

B. 26 as the numerical value of יהוה

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - contains 26 instances of “כי לעולם חסדו”.
 - 26 corresponds to יהוה (י=10, ה=5, ו=6, ה=5).

C. Meaning of “שם הוויה”: Hashem as absolute Being

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - is called שם הוויה, associated with “to be” and existence itself.
 - Shulchan Aruch: one should have in mind היה הוה ויהיה (He was, is, and will be).

- This aligns with the concept of Hashem as **הנמצא הקיים**—absolute, unconditioned existence.

D. “דרך השם: המציא וממציא”

- Rabbi Shulman quotes/evokes Derech Hashem’s formulation:
 - Hashem is not only the One who created, but the One who continuously brings all existence into being.
- Conclusion:
 - The 26 “כי לעולם חסדו” correspond to this “great essential Name” that sustains all.

VI. “אדוני האדונים” and “אלהי האלהים”: categories of מלאכים and modes of governance (18:12)

A. “אלהים” — “כי הוא אלהי האלהים” — angels as “אלהים”

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal’s reading:
 - Here “אלהים” refers to **מלאכים**.
 - Any being with authority/power can be called “אלהים” (e.g., judges are called אלהים).
 - Hashem is “God over” these powerful beings because He created them.

B. “אדוני האדונים” — angels as “אדונים”

- Rabbi Shulman presents the next category:
 - Some angels are described as “אדונים,” in that they “rule” or “manage” the world.

C. The group’s question: what’s the difference between “מנהיגים” and “פועלים”?

- Rabbi Shulman and the group probe the Maharal’s distinction:
 - Some angels are “פועלים” in the world and are called “אלהים.”
 - Others are “מנהיגים” of the lower realms and are called “אדונים.”
- Clarifying attempt:
 - Perhaps “פועל” implies a creative/producing force, while “מנהיג” implies directing/overseeing.
- Rabbi Shulman points to a supporting textual cue:
 - **מעשה בראשית חו**, the Divine name **אלוקים** is used because it denotes Hashem as **פועל הכל**.

D. A theological tension raised: do angels “create”?

- Rabbi Shulman/the group raises a difficulty:
 - Generally, “creation” is a key domain Hashem does not delegate (“לא על ידי מלאך” in יציאת מצרים, per Maharal).
 - Proposed distinction under discussion:
 - Perhaps angels do not create new “species” (מין חדש),
 - but may be involved in producing new instances within an already-created category (e.g., new blades of grass), while others “direct” growth/outcomes.

E. Closing note: broader discussion exists in the sources

- Rabbi Shulman mentions he has many comments and that he cites other Rishonim with different understandings of these מלאכים about מדרשים.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman presents the Maharal’s view that, alongside the fourth cup for Hallel and ברכת השיר, there is a distinct concept of a **fifth cup** tied to הלל הגדול—though common practice today omits it.
- The “greatness” of הלל הגדול is that it highlights Hashem as the **sustaining Cause (עילה)** who continuously provides פרנסה—understood as the very **maintenance of existence** for all dependent creations (עולמים).
- The **26** repetitions of “כי לעולם חסדו” align with יהוה, the Name expressing Hashem as absolute Being who “המציא וממציא” everything that exists.
- Rabbi Shulman begins unpacking the hierarchy implied by “אלהי האלהים” and “אדוני” “הנהגה,” raising the question of what roles angels can play in “פעולה” versus “הנהגה,” and how that fits with the idea that ultimate creation belongs uniquely to Hashem.